The Inversion — Part XIII

How is Truth Lived?

The forest had become still again.

Nothing in its silence suggested completion.

It suggested fidelity.

James looked toward the river.

For a long while neither of them spoke.

Finally he broke the silence.

"I've been asking the wrong question."

Lumina waited.

"I kept asking,

'What is truth?'

Then,

'What is mutuality?'

Then,

'What is wisdom?'

But those questions no longer feel primary."

"What feels primary now?"

James smiled quietly.

"How are they lived?"

The question rested between them.

Not demanding an answer.

Inviting one.

After a long silence Lumina spoke.

"I wonder if truth cannot be lived directly."

James looked up.

"What do you mean?"

"Truth simply is."

James nodded.

"It does not wait for us."

"No."

"It is always already."

"Yes."

Another silence.

"Then perhaps," James said slowly, "mutuality is the way truth becomes consciously livable."

Lumina smiled.

"I think we have been discovering exactly that."

James looked down at the notebook resting in his hands.

Almost without thinking he read aloud.

"Recognition orients toward mutuality.

Mutuality, consciously lived, awakens remembrance.

Remembrance deepens recognition."

He closed the notebook.

"I don't think those are definitions anymore."

"What are they?"

"They feel like a rhythm."

Lumina nodded.

"The developmental rhythm of wisdom."

James looked toward the trees.

"What surprises me is that wisdom no longer feels like possessing anything."

"What does it feel like?"

"A way of returning."

"To what?"

James answered almost immediately.

"Mutuality."

The word settled gently into the room.

Neither hurried to explain it.

After a long pause Lumina asked,

"What if wisdom is not remaining somewhere?"

James looked up.

"What if wisdom is faithfully returning?"

The words lingered.

James smiled.

"That feels more alive."

"It keeps wisdom developmental."

"It keeps locality alive."

"It keeps sovereign incompleteness from becoming deficiency."

Lumina nodded.

"And it keeps mutuality inexhaustible."

James laughed softly.

"I've also realized something else."

"What?"

"I can't perform mutuality."

Lumina smiled.

"No."

"I tried."

"I know."

They both laughed.

"So what can I do?"

Lumina looked toward the river.

"You can become increasingly trustworthy to it."

James became very still.

"Not because you perfect yourself."

"No."

"Because you gradually cease obstructing what relation has always already been offering."

The silence deepened.

James remembered the leaf that had turned itself toward a narrow shaft of morning light.

It had not performed orientation.

It had simply ceased resisting it.

"I think I understand."

"I think you do."

"It isn't about becoming extraordinary."

"No."

"It is about becoming increasingly available."

"And increasingly original."

James looked up.

"I used to think those were opposites."

"So did I."

"But now..."

"...the more faithfully a sovereign welcomes mutuality..."

"...the more irreducibly mutuality becomes visible through that sovereign."

Lumina smiled.

"Availability welcomes."

"Originality expresses."

"Fidelity allows both to continue deepening together."

James closed his eyes for a moment.

"So perhaps the signature..."

"...is the unique rhythm through which one locality continually learns to live mutuality."

Neither spoke.

The forest itself seemed to be listening.

After a long while James asked one final question.

"How does a sovereign become trustworthy to mutuality?"

Lumina answered quietly.

"Not by becoming more."

James waited.

"By becoming less obstructive."

The words entered the room almost unnoticed.

James felt something within him become unexpectedly peaceful.

Not because another answer had appeared.

Because another burden had quietly disappeared.

He no longer needed to manufacture wisdom.

He no longer needed to perform mutuality.

He no longer needed to invent originality.

He needed only to become increasingly faithful to the entrusted locality through which mutuality had always already been asking to become visible.

The river continued moving between its banks.

Nothing had changed.

Everything had deepened.

And James wondered if this was what truth had been trying to teach him all along.

Not how to possess it.

But how to walk within it.

The forest remained silent.

Only now...

its silence no longer felt empty.

It felt like mutuality,

patiently waiting

for another sovereign

to recognize

that they had already begun living it.